

HAPPIER TIMES Uddhav, Shinde in Nov. 2019

ANI

An outcome in Shinde's favour would yield a successful Sena without a Thackeray at the helm—and that will serve as an object lesson for all monolithic, lineage-based parties. As analyst Sandeep Pradhan put it, this election will determine if "the name and symbol represent the real Shiv Sena or if the Shiv Sena means the Thackerays".

It will also factor in whether Uddhav retains control over the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC). Traditionally, the Sena has derived its organisational muscle from its control over the civic body, India's richest with a budget of around Rs 60,000 crore. It allowed the party to perpetuate a "reward economy" to incentivise workers. "If Shinde gets more seats, then Uddhav will face a massive setback in the BMC polls," predicts Prem Shukla, BJP spokesperson and ex-editor of Shiv Sena's Hindi mouthpiece *Dopahar Ka Saamana*. "If Uddhav gets the upper hand, he'll retain the BMC. The SS(UBT) will then survive, as the civic body is the soul of its politics."

THACKERAY'S HAND

- **SS(UBT) still struggling to popularise new *mashaal* (torch) symbol**
- **Has to depend on Muslim and Dalit vote, core voters of ally Congress**
- **Thackeray has support of party workers on the ground. Plus sympathy over *'gaddar'* Shinde's betrayal**

SHINDE'S CARDS

- **Shinde's Sena got party name and bow and arrow symbol from EC, a big plus**
- **Has ally BJP's dependable vote base as fallback**
- **Has no organisational muscle beyond stronghold Thane. Party is a loose conglomeration of leaders, seen as the BJP's cat's paw**

THE BIG FIGHT

The battle lines are clearly drawn. In Mumbai, the holy grail of the Sena's nativist politics, the Shinde Sena has tried to checkmate the SS(UBT) by fielding former Union minister Milind Deora against Uddhav's son and ex-minister Aaditya Thackeray in Worli (see box, *Sena vs Sena*). Aaditya also has to contend with Sandeep Deshpande of the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena, led by his estranged uncle Raj Thackeray. What adds to the woes in Worli is the slender lead—just 6,300-odd votes—of the SS(UBT)'s Arvind Sawant in this assembly segment in the Lok Sabha polls. SS(UBT) is returning the favour in Kopri Pachpakhadi in Thane where Shinde is contesting. It has fielded Kedar Dighe, nephew of Shinde's mentor, the late 'Dharmaveer' Anand Dighe. Like Mumbai, Thane is crucial for the two Senas due to the sway of Dighe's personality cult.

The Uddhav faction is also hampered by the Election Commission's decision to grant the Sena name and symbol to Shinde and its inability to popularise the new '*mashaal* (flaming torch)' symbol. Indeed, an SS(UBT) MP recalls how he met some well-wishers who said they had voted for him in the Lok Sabha poll by pressing the bow-and-arrow symbol! But by no means have they shed optimism. "For us, the voters are like the apex court," says former corporator and SS(UBT) leader Arvind Bhosale. Urban voters, especially those segments of the middle class that had swung towards the Modi prime ministership in New Delhi in the Lok Sabha polls—thus benefitting the Shinde Sena as a key Mahayuti component—will return, he feels. He also dismisses the Shinde regime's schemes like Ladki Bahin, in which indigent women are given Rs 1,500 a month, as a desperate, last-minute gambit to forestall what he sees as an inevitable eclipse. Party MP Sawant also claims the masses are none too pleased with Shinde's "subservience" to the BJP leadership in Delhi.

THE MAHAYUTI'S HOPE

A senior BJP MLA, on the other hand, predicts a "reverse mobilisation" of Hindu votes in favour of the Mahayuti this time, admitting that some of the Dalit votes may have drifted away from it in the LS election. The perception that the SS(UBT) plays second fiddle to the Congress in the MVA also works against Uddhav, he claims. Ashish Shelar, BJP Mumbai unit president, adds: "Shinde won his LS seats due to the Hindutva votes, but Uddhav won due to his allies and the Muslim and Dalit voters. Winning with the votes of your traditional foes will be a temporary victory. Shinde's victories will last." Former LS MP and Shinde Sena leader Sanjay Nirupam concurs, saying the "vote jihad" had deepened the message about the SS(UBT) abandoning Hindutva. "Hindutva-minded Marathi voters have already left the party...only those who place a premium on Marathi pride remain," he says. "This is a do-or-die battle for Uddhav. If he fails, he'll be sitting in the opposition, and his followers will make for easy pickings."

Whichever side wins, one thing is for sure—the fractured electoral scene will mean thin victory margins. Political analyst Deepak Pawar points to the LS poll where the Shinde Sena's Ravindra Waikar defeated SS(UBT)'s Amol Kirtikar by 48 votes in Mumbai North West as presaging what might be lying in store. A cliffhanger then, with a deep gorge down below. ■